

# Day in the Life of a PM

Session 02 · Arun Nandewal · 16 Jul 2026

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There is no single PM day. There are day *types*, and which one you get is set by where your product sits in its lifecycle — plus whatever breaks that morning.

## AT A GLANCE

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- You are handed a **problem statement**, a budget and a set of constraints. Never a feature list.
- Two instructors, one job: Rohit Roy digitises documents at JP Morgan, Arun Nandewal builds Excel and Teams at Microsoft.
- Four questions cover the role: **what** you deliver, **how**, **why**, and **how it performs** once live.
- The house analogy: you hold the vision, design draws the plan, engineering lays the bricks, visitor praise is your KPI.
- Every failure in class came off the happy path — PhonePe UPI Lite paid out ₹2,000 nobody had loaded.
- A good day is decided before it starts: three things, agendas, decline the rest.
- Homework is your first portfolio piece: a “Day in the Life at [company]” one-pager, published on LinkedIn.

## You get problems, not features

Nobody hands a new PM a plate of screens. Rohit’s brief for a whole year was one sentence: the fifteen-year-old platform is being decommissioned, move everything. Sequencing two to three million documents, working around China’s rule that data cannot leave the country, splitting credit-card records from savings records — all of that was his to invent.

## Most PM work is not an app screen

Rohit’s users are bank staff and internal processes; he spent a year on a migration no customer would ever see. Arun’s version from the other side: Excel, Windows and Teams are sold to businesses, but someone opens Excel every morning — a developer, an admin, a marketer — and that person is your persona.

## Strategy is downstream of the vision

Rohit asked the class for WhatsApp’s vision. Retention fails the test; a billion people already open it with nothing to do. Payments is a product, not a vision. The answer was monetisation — one rupee a user is a billion rupees.

CORE CONCEPTS, CONTINUED

Cost is a product decision

You are told to monetise WhatsApp and your answer costs a billion dollars. You do not have a billion dollars. Features get dropped on infrastructure cost alone, and model selection is the live case: use the cheaper model if it answers the basic queries. UPI is the demand-side proof — free built the habit.

Design draws it, engineering builds it

Describe a house on an empty plot and half the room is lost. Sketch it and people say useful things: move that window. With engineering you write the user story, absorb the trade-off — no API means no integration — and negotiate scope. Know which part of a timeline is festival leave and which is curing concrete.

Measure it, or you did not ship it

PhonePe counts transactions and publishes the billions. YouTube shows view counts, and the count itself changes behaviour. Above the KPIs sits one north star — Amazon’s, per Rohit, is customer reviews. Your OKR decides your backlog: raising average order value at Zepto produces buy-two-get-one, while deepening engagement produces richer photography.

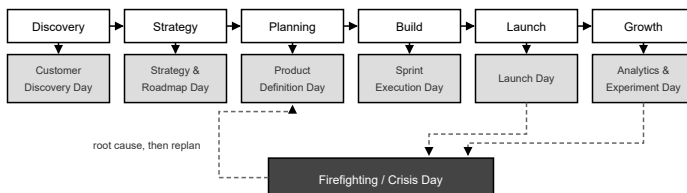
The PRD is the standard

Rohit calls it your Bible — the record that three AC brands were agreed, not every brand in India. Arun calls it a love letter to engineering, design and testing: problem, persona, pain point, workflow, metric, sign-off. He gives it to his wife first. If she cannot follow it, he rewrites.

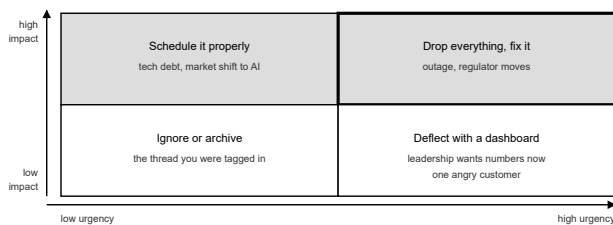
HEARING THE CUSTOMER

| Channel                         | Strength                        | Weakness             |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|
| Direct interviews, 15–20 min    | You watch them get stuck        | Slow; tiny sample    |
| Survey / C-SAT, ~10 questions   | Thousands of users; trend lines | Says what, not why   |
| App store 1- and 2-star reviews | Free, constant, you can reply   | Only the extremes    |
| Support tickets                 | Volume shows the pattern        | Symptoms, not causes |

## THE SHAPE OF THE JOB



Every stage has a matching day type. Firefighting is the branch nobody schedules; its root cause sends you back to planning.



Where an interruption lands decides the response. Beginners treat everything as top-right; the dashboard you build in month one empties the bottom-right box for good.

## EXAMPLES FROM CLASS

- **WhatsApp** — a billion users, almost no revenue. The vision handed down is monetisation; payments is one answer to it, not the vision itself.
- **Mahindra's early EV** — right car, no charging stations. Infrastructure and timing are part of the launch.
- **Flipkart AC installation** — the sale creates a request with Voltas or Samsung, an engineer's calendar and a tracked visit. Ask what happens after the transaction.
- **M365 Copilot** — the first real prompts asked for Satya Nadella's number and a paneer butter masala recipe. Nobody read the documentation. Then it failed in Spanish and the memes started.
- **QR fraud and the Soundbox** — printed codes pasted over merchant codes at petrol pumps; owners took months to notice. The fix became a device that says the payment out loud.
- **Paytm, 7 January** — the RBI restricted the banking licence overnight and the roadmap became crisis management.
- **EPFO** — announced a one-week migration outage on its own site. Users forgive downtime, not guessing.

TRAPS TO AVOID

WHERE BEGINNERS LOSE THE SPRINT

- Reading the report literally. “The scanner is broken” means camera permission was denied two steps earlier.
- Testing only the happy path. Domino’s checked that you paid, not how much, for six months.
- Pricing the design last. A design nobody can afford is not a design.
- Copying a competitor as your roadmap. That is being steered, not steering.

WHAT THE INSTRUCTOR STRESSED

- Name your top three things before the day starts. Never four.
- Declining meetings is the skill. Holding them is not an achievement.
- Say no with data. Fear, reward and gut feel do not work for a PM.
- Ask for help early, and know who the right person is. Half of speed is routing.
- Write a PRD that draws zero follow-up questions. That is the bar.

PRACTICE

- ☐ Build your “Day in the Life at [company]” one-pager. Publish it.
- ☐ Reverse-engineer three defensive features beyond the Soundbox and the ₹5,000 cap.
- ☐ Map one daily flow; find three reports that hide a different cause.
- ☐ Run the three-things habit for seven days. Note what randomised you.
- ☐ Read one app’s “What’s New”. Name the metric that release moves.

GLOSSARY

**JTBD** — the user’s goal, minus your product.

**PRD** — problem, persona, pain, workflow, metric.

**North star** — the one measure you steer by.

**OKR** — objective plus the number you own.

**Randomisation** — anything that hijacks your day.

**Happy path** — the flow where nothing fails.

**Edge case** — the boundary where products break.

**Root cause** — the origin, not the symptom.

**Tech debt** — old shortcuts, repaid in sprint time.

**Persona** — the ideal user you design for.

**Rollback** — reverting a release that broke live.

**C-SAT** — short periodic satisfaction survey.